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Tips For Finding Off-Campus Housing

Whether you're a freshman or a seasoned upperclassman planning for graduation, these tips will help you find off-campus housing effectively.

By Jessica Dickenson

Tags: [budgeting-money](#), [college-student](#), [internships](#), [scholarships](#), [student-housing](#)

Are you done with [dorm living](#) or are you just ready to be independent? Moving off campus is a rite of passage for many college students who for one reason or another, find commuting to be the better choice than dorm living.

Some colleges have strict policies restricting who is allowed to live off-campus. Off-campus living may be only reserved for upperclassmen or students over a specific age. Other campuses may require you to complete additional paperwork before you can legally find a place to live. Make sure you know the housing policies outlined in your student handbook before you sign any kind of lease. The last thing you want is to be saddled with a lease and find out you lost a scholarship or you can't take classes!





Whether you're a freshman or a seasoned upperclassman planning for graduation, these tips will help you find off-campus housing effectively.

Start Early

One of the most important tips for finding off-campus housing is to start your search as early as possible. Chances are if you are looking for housing options near your college or university, other students are doing the same. Many prime locations can get snatched up quickly, especially in popular areas.

Begin your search several months before your desired move-in date to ensure you have a wide selection of available properties. Many students will want their lease to begin in September and end in May, if you could move in earlier and stay longer, you may get priority over those that have a less desirable lease term. You may want to look for [internships](#) over the summer so you can not only land a stellar home but also earn some money over the summer.

Determine Your Budget

Would you even be a college student if you didn't have to worry about money? Before you even begin your search, it's crucial to establish a budget. Rent can vary wildly throughout the United States. While the [national average](#) rent is \$1,702 per month, the average rent in Oklahoma is \$979 and \$2,737 in Connecticut. Always research to see what the average costs are for your area.





look into what the complex charges are before you sign anything. Stick to your budget to avoid financial stress.

ALWAYS LOOK!

Rent is super cheap, the house is only a few miles from campus, you'll have free parking, and all utilities are included - it sounds like a dream come true! Unfortunately, if some things sound too good to be true they probably are. Many college students have moved into less than satisfactory living arrangements under the pretense of a good deal.

It is super important for you to go and look at your living arrangement before you move in. Although landlords aren't purposefully being deceptive, you may find out that you don't like the area as much as you thought or the place is not exactly what you are looking for. Viewing a rental property in advance also allows you to inspect the condition of the property, its amenities, and the surrounding neighborhood. Pay attention to details like safety features, cleanliness, and any potential issues or needed repairs.

Different neighborhoods and homes near your campus will offer varying living experiences. Research the areas to understand their proximity to campus, public [transportation options](#), and access to amenities like grocery stores, restaurants, and recreational areas. This information will help you choose a neighborhood and an apartment that aligns with your preferences and priorities. Never sign a lease without visiting the property in person.





times the amount of rent before they allow you to sign a lease. For example for a rent that is \$1,000 a month, you will need to make \$3,000 a month. Don't make that much? Don't worry! You can always get a [co-signer](#) to your lease or find a roommate. You aren't the first impoverished college student to rent and you won't be the last!

Living with [roommates](#) can significantly reduce your housing expenses. If you're open to sharing a space, look for potential roommates early in your search. Make sure to discuss expectations and responsibilities to ensure a harmonious living situation.

Utilize All Resources

Gone are the days when you had to drive around town looking for "Now Leasing" signs. Numerous online platforms, such as Apartments.com, Craigslist, Zillow, Trulia, and dedicated college housing websites, can simplify your search. These platforms often provide filters to narrow down your options by price, location, and other important factors. Read reviews and contact property owners or managers to ask questions and schedule viewings.

Many colleges and universities host housing fairs where local landlords and property managers showcase available listings. These events can be a valuable resource for finding off-campus housing. Additionally, check with your school's housing office for guidance, listings, and potential roommate-matching services.





Carefully read and understand the lease agreement before signing. You should be aware of your lease terms so that you are fully aware of how long you are legally obligated to stay and/or pay rent. You should also review information such as maintenance policies and rules or regulations so that you know what is expected from you as a resident. If you have questions or concerns, don't hesitate to seek clarification from your landlord.

Create a Checklist

Before moving in, create a checklist of items you'll need for your new place. In your dorm room, you were provided with some staples such as a bed and dresser, but you might not have these items when you move into your off-campus housing. You may have basic kitchen essentials, but you may need to purchase a few other items for your move-in. Make a list that includes furniture, kitchen appliances, and essential household items that you may need. Having a plan will help you budget and ensure a smooth transition to your off-campus housing. Make sure you also have a plan for your [move-in day](#)!

Finding off-campus housing is an enriching experience, offering a taste of independence and adulthood. However, it requires diligent research, financial planning, and careful decision-making. By starting early, setting a budget, and following these tips, you'll be well-prepared to secure a comfortable and suitable living arrangement during your college years. Remember to stay

